

MISSISSIPPI STATE UNIVERSITY™
HIGH PERFORMANCE
COMPUTING COLLABORATORY

ACCEPTABLE USE POLICY

Mississippi State University High Performance Computing Collaboratory

Version 6.0

Revision History:

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1. Purpose

This policy establishes the Mississippi State University High Performance Computing Collaboratory (HPC2) Acceptable Use Policy. This policy is designed to support the HPC2 Information Security Program by outlining the rules for the acceptable use of all HPC2 Information Systems and their associated resources.

2. Scope

The scope of this policy is applicable to all Information Technology (IT) resources owned or operated by HPC2. All users (HPC2 employees, contractors, vendors, or others) of IT resources are responsible for adhering to this policy.

3. Intent

The HPC2 Written Information Security Program serves to be consistent with best practices associated with organizational Information Security management. It is the intent of this policy to ensure that all users of HPC2 are aware of their roles and responsibilities in supporting the HPC2 Information Security Program.

4. Policy

4.1 General Use

4.1.1 It is the responsibility of all HPC2 users to ensure that proprietary information, Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI), or any other sensitive information is protected in a manner consistent with all applicable laws, regulations, policies, and procedures.

4.1.2 HPC2 users may access, use, or share proprietary, controlled, or otherwise sensitive information only to the extent that it is authorized under applicable laws, regulations, policies, and procedures.

4.1.3 Any use of HPC2-provided IT resources, including e-mail, is made with the understanding that such use may not be secure, is not private, is not anonymous, and may be subject to monitoring. Users do not have a right to, nor shall they have an expectation of, privacy while using HPC2-provided IT resources at any time, including accessing the Internet through University-provided connectivity. To the extent that users wish that their private activities remain private, they shall avoid making personal use of University-provided IT resources.

4.1.4 For security and network maintenance purposes, authorized individuals within HPC2 may monitor equipment, systems, and network traffic at any time per the guidelines set forth in the HPC2 Written Information System Program document or the Continuous Monitoring Plan.

4.2 Use of External Information Systems

4.2.1 External Information Systems are information systems or components of information systems for which HPC2 typically would not have direct supervision and authority over the application of security controls or the assessment of security control effectiveness (e.g. personally owned information systems, information systems owned by external

organizations, University information systems operated by departments or entities other than HPC2, etc…).

4.2.2 When used for storing, transmitting, or processing Controlled Unclassified Information, HPC2 allows the use of External Information Systems ONLY when the following criteria have been met: when a valid business or operations reason exists; when a formal risk assessment of the third party has been conducted; when all identified risks have been appropriately mitigated; and, when a formal contract or agreement exists as appropriate.

4.2.3 Connecting an External Information System to the HPC2 network for activities that do not involve Controlled Unclassified Information is restricted to those instances where a valid business purpose exists AND when a user has received HPC Computing Office management approval.

4.3 Wireless Access

4.3.1 All wireless network infrastructure devices at any HPC2 or HPC2-affiliated facility or connected to an HPC2 network must be installed, maintained, and supported by the HPC staff. Individuals are not authorized to install wireless network infrastructure devices without the explicit authorization from HPC2 Computing Office management.

4.3.2 Wireless network infrastructure devices must use HPC2 management approved authentication and encryption protocols.

4.3.3 Wireless devices must maintain a MAC address that can be registered and tracked.

4.3.4 Newly installed wireless network infrastructure devices must not interfere with wireless technologies currently in use by HPC2, its affiliated centers and institutes, and any other constituent organizations.

4.4 Security of HPC2 Information Systems

4.4.1 In general, HPC2 non-privileged users do not have the ability to install software on HPC2 information systems. However, when authorized, users will ensure that software, including downloaded software, is properly licensed, free of malicious code, and authorized before installing and using it on organization-owned systems.

4.4.2 In general, software purchased with university funds may only be installed on university-owned systems and may not be installed on personally-owned systems. Furthermore, in general, software procured through the HPC2 may only be installed on HPC2-inventoried systems.

4.4.3 Users will log off of or lock their systems when they walk away from them.

4.4.4 Users will secure sensitive information (on paper and in electronic formats) when left unattended or when unauthorized personnel are present.

4.4.5 All HPC2 users are required to complete security awareness training before accessing any system and on an annual basis thereafter. Only authorized users will be allowed to access HPC2 information systems.

4.4.6 Any electronic or print media containing sensitive information shall be destroyed in an approved manner. HPC2 provides designated locations where users can drop off print media to be destroyed in accordance with organizational requirements.

4.5 Physical Security

4.5.1 All individuals within HPC2 facilities will wear HPC2-issued identification badges at all times in organization-operated facilities.

4.6 Remote Access

4.6.1 Installation or use of unapproved VPN client software or services on HPC2 information systems is prohibited.

4.6.2 Configuration or use of VPN clients or services on HPC2 information systems to support outbound connections is prohibited without prior authorization from the HPC2 Computing Office.

4.6.3 Individuals downloading or using the HPC2 VPN client are required to comply with all laws and regulations governing use, export, re-export, and transfer of products, technology, and services. Individuals on the U.S. Department of Commerce's Denied Persons List or affiliated lists, the U.S. Department of Treasury's Specially Designated Nationals List or any Government export exclusion lists are prohibited from downloading the HPC2 VPN client software.

4.6.4 The HPC2 VPN client and Secure Shell (SSH) are the only allowed and authorized mechanisms for remote access to the HPC2 network. Users must understand that, when using VPN, their machine becomes a de facto extension of the HPC2 network. As such, all the same laws, regulations, policies, and procedures apply in the same manner that they apply to devices physically connected to the HPC2 network. Controlled or other sensitive information obtained because of their affiliation with HPC2 shall not be stored on personally owned or other unapproved devices.

4.6.5 Secure Shell (SSH) is the only approved protocol for remote login to HPC2 computing resources.

4.7 Alternate Worksites

4.7.1 Alternate worksites are locations where an individual performs their assigned duties on a regular or recurring basis that are not certified as HPC2 CUI-compliant locations. The HPC2 Computing Office Director is the authority for determining if a location is HPC2 CUI-compliant. The High Performance Computing Center building, the Center for Advanced Vehicular Systems building, and the Science and Technology Center building at Stennis Space Center are HPC2 CUI-compliant locations.

4.7.2 The use of alternate worksites for projects or activities that involve Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) must meet all the security requirements outlined in NIST SP 800-171 or any other applicable laws, regulations, or policies.

4.8 Foreign Travel with Computers and other Electronic Devices

4.8.1 Individuals traveling to a foreign country on business related to their official duties as an employee of or affiliate with HPC2 may be authorized to take their HPC2-issued laptop provided that they are not working on a controlled project.

4.8.2 Those individuals who work on controlled projects including technologies subject to Export Administration Regulations (EAR) or International Traffic in Arms Regulations (ITAR) -or which involves CUI or proprietary information- are prohibited from taking any laptop, external media, or other electronic device which is normally used to store or process information related to the project. Individuals working on controlled projects may request a laptop from the Office of Research Security (ORS) prior to their scheduled departure.

4.8.3 Beyond export laws, HPC2 personnel should be aware that overseas travel may result in the unexpected disclosure or compromise of sensitive data stored on electronic devices. Any theft, loss, or compromise of sensitive information related to HPC2 research or other affiliated activities should be reported in accordance with paragraph 4.8 of the HPC2 Acceptable Use Policy.

4.9 Unacceptable Use

The following activities are, in general, prohibited. Employees may be exempted from these restrictions by the HPC2 Computing Office management during the course of their legitimate job responsibilities.

Under no circumstances is an HPC2 user or employee authorized to engage in any activity that is illegal under local, state, federal or international law or in violation of any organizational policies while utilizing organization-owned resources.

HPC2 users shall NOT:

4.9.1 Direct or encourage others to violate organizational policies, procedures, standards or guidelines.
4.9.2 Circumvent security safeguards or reconfigure systems except as authorized (e.g., violation of the least privilege control).
4.9.3 Use another user's account, identity, or password.
4.9.4 Use clear text passwords or custom auto login code or scripts when connecting to HPC2 systems.
4.9.5 Exceed authorized access to controlled or otherwise sensitive information.
4.9.6 Cause deliberate congestion, delay, or disruption of service to any organization-owned IT resource.
4.9.7 Store controlled or otherwise sensitive information in public folders, cloud providers, or other unsecure or unapproved physical or electronic storage locations.
4.9.8 Share sensitive information, except as authorized by any applicable laws, regulations, policies, and procedures and with formal agreements that ensure third parties will adequately protect it.
4.9.9 Transport, transfer, email, remotely access, or download sensitive information, inclusive of Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI), unless such action is explicitly permitted by an authorized manager or owner of such information.
4.9.10 Store controlled or otherwise sensitive information on mobile devices such as laptops, smartphones, USB flash drives, or on remote systems without authorization or appropriate safeguards, as stipulated by organization policies.
4.9.11 Knowingly or willingly conceal, remove, mutilate, obliterate, falsify, or destroy data with the intent to, or where the effect produces, harm to HPC2 or Mississippi State University.
4.9.12 Use HPC2-provided IT resources for non-HPC2 related business purposes or "for-profit" purposes of the user.
4.9.13 Establish unauthorized personal, commercial or non-profit organizational web pages on HPC2-provided systems.
4.9.14 Use HPC2-owned IT resources as a staging ground or platform to gain unauthorized access to other systems.

4.9.15 Use HPC2-owned IT resource for activities that are inappropriate or offensive to fellow employees or the public. Such activities include, but are not limited to hate speech, harassment, bullying, intimidation or other abusive conduct that ridicules others on the basis of race, creed, religion, color, age, sex, disability, national origin, or sexual orientation.

4.9.16 Add any IT resources to existing HPC2-owned systems without the appropriate management authorization, including the installation of network devices and reconfiguration of systems.

4.9.17 Install any peer-to-peer file sharing software, web services, or other collaborative software without receiving prior approval from HPC2 Computing Office management.

4.9.18 Intentionally acquire, use, reproduce, transmit, or distribute any controlled information including computer software and data that includes information subject to the Privacy Act, copyrighted, trademarked or material with other intellectual property rights (beyond fair use), proprietary data, or export controlled software or data.

4.9.19 Remove University-provided IT resources from organization property without prior management authorization.

4.9.20 Remotely activate collaborative computing devices including, but not limited to, VTC's, VOIP phones, networked white boards, video cameras, or white boards.

4.9.21 Use unauthorized collaborative hardware or software products to discuss or share CUI without the express approval from and oversight by the HPC2 Computing Office. For example, these products might include, but are not limited to, Cisco Webex, Cisco Webex Teams, GoToMeeting, Microsoft Teams, Smartboards, VTC equipment and related peripherals, etc…

4.9.22 Grant remote access to or control of any HPC2 Information System to any user, whether internal or external to HPC2, without the express consent of and oversight by the HPC2 Computing Office. This includes, for example, allowing a remote user in a collaborative session like Microsoft Teams or Cisco Webex to control an HPC2 Information System.

4.9.23 Modify software or software configurations without HPC2 Computing Office management approval.

4.9.24 Run "sniffers" (utilities used to monitor network traffic, commonly used to spy on other network users and attempt to collect their passwords), port scanners, or any hacker-related software on an HPC2 system, or network without the express approval from HPC2 Computing Office management.

4.9.25 Log into HPC2 resources remotely where monitor can be seen by non-HPC personnel (e.g., public areas, coffee shops). Remote login from private locations (home, hotel room) is permissible.

4.9.26 Publish Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) on publicly accessible websites (e.g. facebook, twitter, departmental web servers, etc…).

4.9.27 Use external media such as thumb drives or external hard drives to store CUI.

4.10 Reporting

4.10.1 All HPC2 users have the responsibility to promptly report the theft, loss, or unauthorized disclosure of any proprietary, controlled, or otherwise sensitive information.
HPC2 users must immediately report all lost or stolen equipment, known or suspected security incidents, known or suspected security policy violations or compromises, or suspicious activity.

5. Policy Compliance

5.1 Compliance Verification

HPC2 staff will verify compliance with this policy through various methods, including but not limited to, automated system reports, internal and external audits, and reports from HPC2 users and staff.

5.2 Exceptions

The Director of High Performance Computing must approve any requested exceptions to this policy.

5.3 Non-Compliance

Any employee or user found in violation of this policy may be subject to disciplinary action such as: loss of account, verbal or written reprimand, other disciplinary actions, or criminal/civil prosecution.

6. Related Policies

HPC2 Incident Response Policy, March 2018

High Performance Computing Collaboratory Operational Policies, May 2013

Appendix A - References

The following references illustrate public guidance which has been issued on the subject of information security and should be used to demonstrate the responsibilities associated with protection of its information assets.

a. United States Department of Commerce National Institute for Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication 800-171 Protecting Controlled Unclassified Information in Nonfederal Systems and Organizations Revision 1 December 2016.

b. HPC2 Written Information Security Program document March 2018.